Yatra Diaries: The Way It Was

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Pain. The first thing—the only thing—you feel is pain. Rivers and seas, acres of pain as the skin begins to peel from the soles of your feet and you leak blood into your sneakers. Or your body breaks out in livid, agonizing rashes in the unending, unrelenting humidity of Kerala. Or, for no ostensible reason, you just wake up one day with high fever, barely able to put two coherent sentences together.

No matter, you are a yatri, and you have to keep walking. The heart pumping at the rock-concert-like launch of the Bharat Jodo Yatra on the Kanyakumari beach is a distinct memory.

The first few weeks of the Bharat Jodo Yatra were also a diary of pain as the walkers set out on the journey of a lifetime. Most people can probably walk 15 or 20 kilometres if they have to only do it for a single day. You can possibly do it the next day and, just maybe, the next. But then try doing it day after day with no end in sight, and very quickly your willpower declines exponentially. You begin to ignore the beautiful south Indian landscape you are walking through, its magnificent beaches and the tree-lined highways. You only focus on putting one foot ahead of the other for the next hundred metres, for the next kilometre, for the next break point for much-needed water or food.

It didn’t matter if you were Rahul Gandhi, who suffered from an injured knee, or Kanhaiya Kumar, who had a burning fever and a shoulder injury, or yatri Rahul Jog from Haryana, who was hit by a (thankfully slow-moving) car. They all kept going.

For every walker the Bharat Jodo Yatra was first and foremost an intensely personal exercise. Take away the stirring speeches, the call to a